Kiran Rao's *Laapataa Ladies* has two new brides (Nitanshi Goel and Pratibha Ranta) getting lost, only to come of age and achieve their potential. The comedy drama takes a satirical, gentle route to smash patriarchy and in doing so paints endearing portraits of its female characters. There's also a hapless husband (Sparsh Srivastava) and Ravi Kishan as an inspector adding to the humour. It's Rao's first film in 13 years, a long interval for a filmmaker whose debut, *Dhobi Ghat*, signalled the rise of an ingenious, nuanced voice in the Hindi film industry.

Rao is all too familiar with an artist's insatiable hunger to see their name on things. "I pressured myself a lot," she says. "I never got to that stage where I could share things with the world, which was very frustrating. But I also didn't want to do it for the sake of doing it and be not fully happy with it." There's no room for remorse or regrets, as it wasn't a full-fledged sabbatical. Rao was creatively involved in all of Aamir Khan's productions—*Dangal* (2016), *Secret Superstar* (2017) and *Laal Singh Chaddha* (2022)—while also simultaneously developing projects of her own including one on artist Gauhar Jaan, a script set in New Delhi and a non-fiction series. Raising her son Azad was also a happy creative endeavour.

In 2018, Khan excitedly shared with her a 'fun story' he heard at a screenwriting competition of which he was a judge. Its premise—wives being swapped on a train—was absurdist, but, for Rao, it offered a "fantastic blank canvas" to embed various issues, from dowry and domestic abuse to female agency and self-sufficiency. "As women, we often don't give ourselves time and space to explore what we want to be and do, and society doesn't allow us either," says Rao. That she and the writers—Biplab Goswami (story), Sneha Desai and Divyanidhi Singh (on dialogues)—do so, never losing the humorous cadence, makes the film all the more endearing. "Comedy disarms you," she adds. "You can say a lot of things that people otherwise would take offence to and do it with subtext rather than it being on the nose." One bride finds a life guru of sorts (Chhaya Kadam) at a train station; another's assuredness shakes the women in the household.

LAAPATAA LADIES ALSO MARKS THE DEBUT OF KIRAN RAO'S BANNER KINDLING PICTURES

With the film, Rao also got wings of her own. It marks the debut of her banner Kindling Pictures, which she describes as "a creative lab" where

